



AI content moderation for Tumblr

According to Tumblr, NSFW content will be flagged using a mix of machine-learning classification and human moderation. <https://digit.in/feb19-37>



AMDs processor lawsuit continues

The case against AMD 'misrepresenting' the number of cores in old FX processors has been given a go ahead. <https://digit.in/feb19-38>

Bandersnatched

We take a nosedive into the entire history of interactive storytelling

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ave you seen Bandersnatch yet? In December 2018, Netflix released the latest entry into its

anthology series *Black Mirror* in the form of *Bandersnatch*, an interactive movie where you get to make decisions for the characters as the story goes. While the storytelling itself deserves a mention, it's the format and the ability to influence the characters' lives that has made people go crazy about it.

A large number of people are under the impression that this is the first time interactive storytelling has been attempted. The truth is, it is not even the first interactive movie. It's more than half a century too late for that milestone. Surprised? How about the fact that interactive storytelling has existed since time immemorial?

HOW INTERACTIVE ENTERTAINMENT IS ANCIENT

If you think about it, we've been enjoying interactive entertainment for ages now, as a civilisation. Theatre plays, operas, sports and quite a few other forms of entertainment have traditionally been quite interactive, with the audience cheering, booing, and if it's really bad, even throwing stuff at the performers.

However, it wasn't just restricted to being present for the performance or reacting to it. Some early instances of interactive storytelling actually did let

the audience participate. Back in 1936, *Night of January 16th*, a play by Ayn Rand that was initially titled *Woman on Trial*, let members of the audience play the role of the jury in a murder trial; the play would proceed on to one of two narratives depending on the verdict. However, the first gamebook, which is what books with interactive storytelling are called, predates the play by four to six years.



The earliest known examples of theatre venues, where the entertainment was literally surrounded by its audience, date as far back as 4th century BC

GAMEBOOKS A.K.A CHOOSE YOUR OWN ADVENTURE

Back in the 60s, somewhere on the other side of the world, a father was telling bedtime stories to his daughters when he ran out of ideas. Not knowing what to do, he decided to ask them what Pete, the protagonist, should do next on the isolated island he was on. The next thing he knew, his daughters were enthusiastically suggesting one option after another as he crafted multiple storylines for Pete that night. That very same night, Edward Packard picked a particular storyline for himself as well – that of turning this idea into a successful book. *The Adventures of You on Sugarcane Island*,

written in 1969 and released in 1976, went on to spawn the popular *Choose Your Own Adventure* (CYOA) series that published more than 60 titles.

However, the earliest known gamebook came out almost forty years before that. *Consider the Consequences!* by Doris Webster and Mary Alden Hopkins not only predates Packard's work, but it also predates what has been considered to be the first visualisation

of CYOA genre stories by almost 75 years. On the other hand, the genre was quite popular in other languages even before CYOA arrived officially, but gained mass popularity in the 80s with CYOA. However, the fate of interactive storytelling was headed down a branch that would take it to the domain of moving pictures.

THE MERGING OF VIDEO AND GAMING: INTERACTIVE MOVIES

There wasn't any major role for technology in interactive storytelling until someone decided to put it up on the big screen. The 1967 movie, *Kinoautomat*, is often cited as the first example of interactive cinema. In its initial screening, the audience was seated in a theatre where every single one of the 127 seats had a pair of buttons. This had let the audience make decisions, led by the narrator,



A few examples of the Choose Your Own Adventure series